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MODI'S NEW VESHTI STRATEGY

Rich cultural symbolism dominates a Modi visit to poll-bound TN, but sceptics aren't sure of saffron's sync with Tamil identity

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**



'LIVING GANGAI KONDAN', say BJP bhakts, as Modi poses in front of Thanjavur's iconic Brihadiswara temple

IT WAS A SUBLIMELY choreographed moment of political theatre, of the grandiose genre that has long been seen to befit the man. Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the ancient Brihadiswara Temple, holding a vessel of *gangajal* from Kashi, framed against the *gopuram* and the blue Tamil skies behind. That July 27 image from Gangaikonda Chozhapuram, tweeted by BJP leader H. Raja with the caption 'Living Gangai Kondan', went viral. The symbolism was thick, and hard to miss.

Modi's two-day visit to Tamil Nadu, beginning July 26, also brought the usual rain of inaugurations: infrastructure projects worth Rs 4,800 crore, including the expansion of the VO Chidambaranar Port, and a Rs 450-crore terminal at the airport.

CULTURAL MESSAGING

If all that is a necessary part of the script in the BJP's push for the 2026 assembly election, it was the cultural spectacle and messaging that dominated the debates. Modi released a commemorative coin in honour of Rajendra Chola I, listened to Odhuvar recitations of Shaivite hymns, and attended a spiritual concert by Ilaiyaraaja. Flanked by heads of prominent Shaivaite *mutts*, he described the Chola empire as a "blueprint for Viksit Bharat", praising its maritime influence and administrative acumen as early examples of Indian greatness.

Supporters hailed the gesture as a reclamation of Tamil legacy. Critics, however, saw it as a calculated attempt to reinterpret Tamil history through a Hindutva prism. "If Rajendra Chola was hailed as Gangai Kondan, it was because he defeated rulers of the Gangetic plains, not because he brought Ganga water," says political commentator Priyan. "The ASI's refusal to accept the antiquity of Keezhadi reflects the BJP's actual views."

Actor-politician Vijay weaponised